

Sublime

where intellectual conversations meet aesthetic refinement

Have you ever stood before a painting and felt it took you to another world? That's exactly what happened to me when I visited the National Palaces Painting Museum, tucked right next to Dolmabahçe Palace in Istanbul. Hidden like a gem, this museum holds an incredible collection spanning different eras and styles. But for me, it was the Romantic period that stole the show.

As I wandered through the collection, I was captivated by the dramatic contrasts of light and shadow in the paintings. Those epic beams of light piercing through darkness seemed to carry me away—to a place where clouds stood still, silently observing the eternal dance of light and shadow. I stood there, mesmerized, not entirely sure why it moved me so deeply.

Later, I discovered that some of these breathtaking works were painted by Abdulmecid Efendi, the last caliph of the Ottoman Empire. This revelation left me even more fascinated. These masterpieces belonged to the Romantic movement—a period that emerged after the French Revolution as a response to the rigidity of classical art and the rationalism of the Enlightenment. Romanticism celebrated emotion, imagination, individuality, and the sublime over cold logic and reason. To me, it also celebrated love—a love so pure it breaks through fear and darkness.

Learning that Abdulmecid Efendi was a part of this movement made his work even more intriguing. His role as the last caliph adds a layer of unexpected depth to his Romantic tendencies, especially within the Ottoman context. Perhaps, through his art, he was saying farewell to his empire, memorializing it with beauty and emotion.

Isn't that what Romanticism is all about? To reflect on the past, to find love and beauty in it, and to let it guide us forward. As we enter this new year, that's my hope: to leave behind the shadows of the past and let the light shine through.

If you have the chance, visit the National Palaces Painting Museum. Whether it's the Romantic period or another style, I promise something there will move you. And if you do visit, let me know which works speak to you—I'd love to hear about it.

Welcome to 2024, and welcome to my page!

Paolo Sorrentino: The Director Who Finds Beauty in Chaos

Let me take you into the quiet elegance of Paolo Sorrentino's world—a space where beauty and chaos collide. Sorrentino is real. He doesn't shy away from life's raw truths or try to sanitize them for the sake of art. What's there is there, and what's done is done. In his films, he finds beauty in the chaos of real life, capturing its imperfections and fleeting moments of clarity. His work is a reminder that life, in all its messiness, is worth reflecting upon.

When comparing his style to that of directors like Gaspar Noé, Sorrentino's approach feels notably different. While Noé's dance scenes are ecstatic, pulsating with raw energy and feverish intensity, Sorrentino's are gentle and smooth, as if the camera itself is swaying to the rhythm. His direction brings a sense of grace and subtlety, allowing emotions to unfold naturally rather than hitting the viewer with sensory overload.

Sorrentino's cinematography also stands out for its remarkable fluidity. The camera glides effortlessly through his stories, often giving the impression of a documentary—not in style but in essence. It feels like a "human documentary," intimately observing the characters as they navigate the labyrinth of their lives. This sense of observation brings authenticity to his work, making his films feel as though they are quietly eavesdropping on life itself.

Another hallmark of Sorrentino's work is his ability to weave humor with profound philosophical musings. His films often find moments of levity in the midst of existential reflection, striking a balance that few filmmakers can achieve. Whether it's a witty line or an absurd scenario, the humor doesn't detract from the depth—instead, it enriches it, reminding us that even in the weightiest moments, there's room for laughter. And we understand yet again, Paolo Sorrentino's films are not just cinema; they're immersive journeys into the sublime, where every frame feels like a masterpiece.

Tomorrow, I'll dive into the thought-provoking endings of *La Grande Bellezza* and *Youth*—what do they mean, and how do they reflect Sorrentino's vision?

The endings of Sorrentino's films often linger in ambiguity, leaving the viewer in a state of introspection. In *La Grande Bellezza*, the closing moments find Jep Gambardella imagining his first love, perhaps confronting emotions he'd buried for years. This could symbolize his journey

to rediscover the beauty and authenticity that had been missing from his life. It feels like a poignant acknowledgment of a past he couldn't reconcile until now.

In *Youth*, Michael Caine's character finally agrees to conduct the orchestra, a moment that might represent letting go of guilt or reclaiming his passion and purpose after years of detachment. This act, sudden yet profound, encapsulates the film's meditation on aging, regret, and renewal. Sorrentino's endings are less about resolution and more about inviting the audience to reflect on love, guilt, and the passage of time.

Sorrentino's films are more than stories; they are meditations on life. They invite us to sit with our imperfections, laugh at our absurdities, and marvel at the beauty that emerges from the chaos. Through his smooth camera work, gentle storytelling, and profound observations, Sorrentino reminds us that cinema, at its best, reflects the deepest truths of what it means to be human.

Through his work, Sorrentino invites us into a world where beauty, chaos, and humanity collide—an invitation few directors can extend with such elegance.

Do you see *La Grande Bellezza*'s ending as a reflection of Jep's reconciliation with his past? Or is it something else entirely?

Art Nouveau, Gustav Klimt, and Jewelry: A Golden Connection

What connects the flowing lines of Art Nouveau, the golden brilliance of Gustav Klimt, and the timeless elegance of jewelry? They share a pursuit of beauty, craftsmanship, and an integration of art into everyday life that remains captivating over a century later.

The Birth of Art Nouveau: A New Aesthetic

Art Nouveau emerged in the late 19th century as a reaction against industrialization and the rigid traditions of academic art. It sought to blur the lines between fine art and functional design, creating a unified aesthetic inspired by nature—with its flowing lines, intricate details, and organic motifs. This philosophy extended into architecture, graphic design, and, notably, jewelry.

Jewelry from this period broke away from traditional styles dominated by precious stones. Instead, artisans like René Lalique and Louis Comfort Tiffany experimented with enameling, semi-precious stones, and materials like glass. Designs often featured sinuous, plant-like forms and ethereal creatures such as dragonflies and peacocks. These pieces were not just adornments; they were wearable works of art.

Gustav Klimt: The Golden Visionary

Around the same time, Gustav Klimt, a leader of the Vienna Secession movement, was redefining the boundaries of art with his bold, innovative works. His "Golden Phase," characterized by the lavish use of gold leaf, became iconic. Paintings like *The Kiss* and *Portrait of Adele Bloch-Bauer I* are masterclasses in the interplay of intricate patterns, luminous gold, and sensuous forms.

Klimt's work embodies the Art Nouveau ethos of combining beauty and meaning. His compositions, rich with flowing lines and natural motifs, echo the patterns and materials seen in Art Nouveau jewelry. In many ways, Klimt's paintings feel like jewelry themselves—ornamental, detailed, and luxurious.

Jewelry as Wearable Art

The connection between Klimt's aesthetic and jewelry is most evident in the craftsmanship of the Art Nouveau period. Jewelers like Louis Comfort Tiffany, inspired by the same natural forms and intricate designs, created pieces that mirrored the ornate beauty of Klimt's works. Tiffany & Co.'s early 20th-century creations, such as their nature-inspired necklaces and enamel pieces, share the same spirit of elegance and artistry.

A Timeless Legacy

Both Klimt and Art Nouveau jewelers sought to elevate everyday objects into realms of art. This philosophy has a lasting impact, influencing contemporary jewelry designers who continue to draw from these golden, intricate styles. Brands like Tiffany & Co. maintain this legacy by blending timeless craftsmanship with modern aesthetics, often revisiting the organic motifs and fluid lines that defined Art Nouveau.

Whether through Klimt's gilded paintings or a Tiffany necklace, this period reminds us that beauty is not confined to galleries or museums. It can be worn, touched, and experienced—a golden connection that transcends time.

What's your favorite Art Nouveau piece or artist? Does Klimt's golden vision inspire you as much as it inspires me? Let me know in the comments!